

■ By Amarnath K. Menon

He may be 148 films old and worth more than Rs 1,200 crore but he is an actor with much more than millions in the bank. He commands Rs 8 crore a film and now the Telugu superstar is a runaway success off screen as well. Leading from the front by donating blood thrice a year, he has translated his immense popularity

blood DIAMOND

✱ **Chiranjeevi, 52**

Project An eye and blood bank that helps millions across Andhra Pradesh

Can-do Icon Mother Teresa, who put service before self and once said 'do not wait for leaders, do it alone, person to person'



9 million units is the requirement of blood in India annually but only six million units are collected

into an invaluable service for society. On reading a heart wrenching story of four young men dying for want of adequate replenishment of blood in a local newspaper in 1996, Chiranjeevi, Telugu film's reigning deity, decided to do in real life what he had so often done in films—save lives. Announcing the launch of a blood bank on August 22, 1997, he led fans of the Chiranjeevi Youth Association in donating blood himself at an especially convened camp in Hyderabad. In little over a year, by October 1998, the blood bank was operational in a makeshift rented accommodation with the aim of collecting and providing safe blood free to all.

Even as Chiranjeevi began developing infrastructure to draw, store, and distribute blood, he took every opportunity to tackle and overcome the twin challenges of misinformation and lack of motivation among voluntary donors. Many of his 148 films in the last three decades have made this more widely known in a direct or subtle manner. Chiranjeevi emphasises on the need to donate blood and eyes. In a personal touch, he also takes time out to listen to the donors and encourage them. At film launches, he honours outstanding donors to dispel the myth that frequent donation makes a person weak. He also visits the blood bank occasionally where he meets donors, poses for photographs and even signs autographs.

At Hyderabad's swank Chiranjeevi Eye and Blood Bank (CEBB), which is open round the clock, a large number of donors ensures supply is always greater than demand even

if it is a rare blood group. It is perhaps the only one among the 2,433 blood banks across the country, or at least in Andhra Pradesh, where replacement for blood issued is not insisted upon as there is a dearth of donors. CEBB collects, screens and stores blood in the most hygienic way. '*Rakthadhaanam, mahadhaanam*' (blood donation is the greatest donation) is his slogan that enthralls many, among the actors like Maharshi Raghava and Krishna Goud, his fans, IT professionals, bankers and even some students, who give blood once a quarter. "Chiranjeevi has a match among other film stars in using his popularity for the betterment of society," says Raghava.

CEBB has it all—biometric identification of the prospective donor with comprehensive details of the blood group, where he/she can be contacted and an identity card to make it possible for the blood bank managers to direct them to 300-odd big and medium-sized hospitals. CEBB has 92,000 regular registered donors, of about 2 million voluntary donors in India, mostly in the 20-35 age group. At the same time, donor clubs have emerged in Hyderabad, Visakhapatnam, Kakinada, Vijayawada and Rajahmundry where members range between 12,000 and 15,000 in each club. On receiving a call, travel at personal expense to hospitals twice, first to get their blood screened and then to be at hand to donate it when required for the patient. Inspired by Chiranjeevi donors, banks and other institutions are also organising